

Among my prized digital records are two longish interviews with Tony (see box). In one, he tells me about his vision for computer education in schools. Goa is one of the early starters in this field, initially propounded by non-resident networks, but the small state seems to have lost its tempo on what was possible. In the other recording, Tony takes me on a grand 100-minute tour of his little village, Moira in North Goa, pointing to every nook and cranny of his favourite part of the planet.

Memories

Check these out here:

Schools and the keyboard... in Goa
<https://archive.org/details/it-schools>

Moira... on a motorcycle
<https://youtu.be/yydERUkS1Nk>

Tony's background was that of a school administrator, and it was reflected in his concerns. He has narrated (online) how his school too got access to computers in the early 1990s under the MP constituency development scheme "and none of us knew anything about computers".

So they first used the PC as a glorified typewriter. Then, they realised they could create their paybills on Lotus1-2-3. It became even easier with Excel, and formulae for calculating dearness allowances and house rent allowances (DA/HRA) for every teacher became "so easy".

"As part of the Goa Headmasters Association, we offered this facility to every school in Goa, right down to Canacona (at the extreme southern end of Goa). It saved on time, brought in accuracy and speed," he recalled.

Tony felt that Indian techies could do a lot to localise school-related software. He suggested the creation and adoption of affordable (and shareable) time-table software, school registration free software, and school-linked system software (which exists overseas but needs to be localised to Indian conditions).

"We have lesson plans, but nobody's sharing those. We could think of a website where lessons could be freely downloaded," he suggested, the free/libre and open source approach clearly showing up.

He felt upset over the way computers were being used only "sub-optimally" in schools in Goa, despite so much being spent on hardware. School students also needed basic things like typing and keyboard skills, he felt.

Tony was born in Tanzania, in the northeastern city of Arusha. Barely a couple of years ago, he was really happy to get the chance to revisit the land of his birth. (In the past century, many from the Great Goan Diaspora landed up for work and opportunity in what was then

British East Africa.) With the enthusiasm of a gushing schoolboy, he narrated how he had visited his old home and found the penknife-etched marks on wood that he had left behind maybe six decades ago.

Tony returned to Goa as a young teenager in the 1960s.

When we motorbiked around his village just earlier this year, he shared the challenges of life here in those times. He narrated how the only bridge to the river-surrounded village was being rebuilt, and one needed to take a canoe to get across, and a lot more. This encounter turned out to be a sociology, history, geography, agriculture and Konkani lesson based on Moira, for me!

Altruism was indeed Tony's middle name. Just thinking of what more he could have done if given some more time makes one sad. He was ever ready to support a good cause. A religious person himself, even while being broadminded and tolerant, he was a mainstay to the tiny local chapel next to his home.

On Facebook, he ran his village network *Moira-Net* virtually single-handedly. Yes, some of Goa's villages do have their own networks too.

After retiring, again, Tony took to writing seriously. He was an active member of the GoaWriters group, and current admin of its online network, a task he did with amazing seriousness and dedication. He was a trustee of the Green Ray Foundation, which aimed to spread environmental awareness among Goan schoolchildren, supported with expat Goan generosity.

Some years back, Tony readily stepped in to play the role of a volunteer admin for Goanet, a social media network built some 26 years ago — long before the time of Instagram, Twitter, Facebook, Wikipedia, and even Google! He virtually single-handedly built a 10,000+ membership for the *Goanet@Facebook* network.

All his work and contribution resulted in an outpouring of love and sympathy on his passing, both online and offline. On his death, many remembered his quiet nature, his few words and his shy smile.

But his actions said it all.

Go in peace, Tony. You will be missed and remembered with gratitude.  **END**

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